THE CHALLENGES AHEAD

With Modi at the helm, and Union home minister Amit Shah ably assisting him, the BJP has transformed itself into an electoral juggernaut that treats every election as though its very survival depended on it. The party mounts not just the heavy artillery of leaders but has also built a dedicated cadre to execute its vision and mission on the ground. It has perfected the science of election management right down to the booth level, with a system of *panna samiti*s and *pramukh*s, *shakti kendra*s and digital armies to cover the last mile and reach voters at home. The BJP constantly reviews its performance and acts on lessons drawn from each major election. For instance, both in Gujarat as well as in Himachal Pradesh, the party lowered its pro-Hindutva pitch; did not allow leaders above the age of 70 to contest or allowed their kin to fill in for them. It pushed hard to make deeper inroads among the Dalit and tribal communities. The final embellishment on all these efforts was the tremendous connect that Modi has with the electorate.

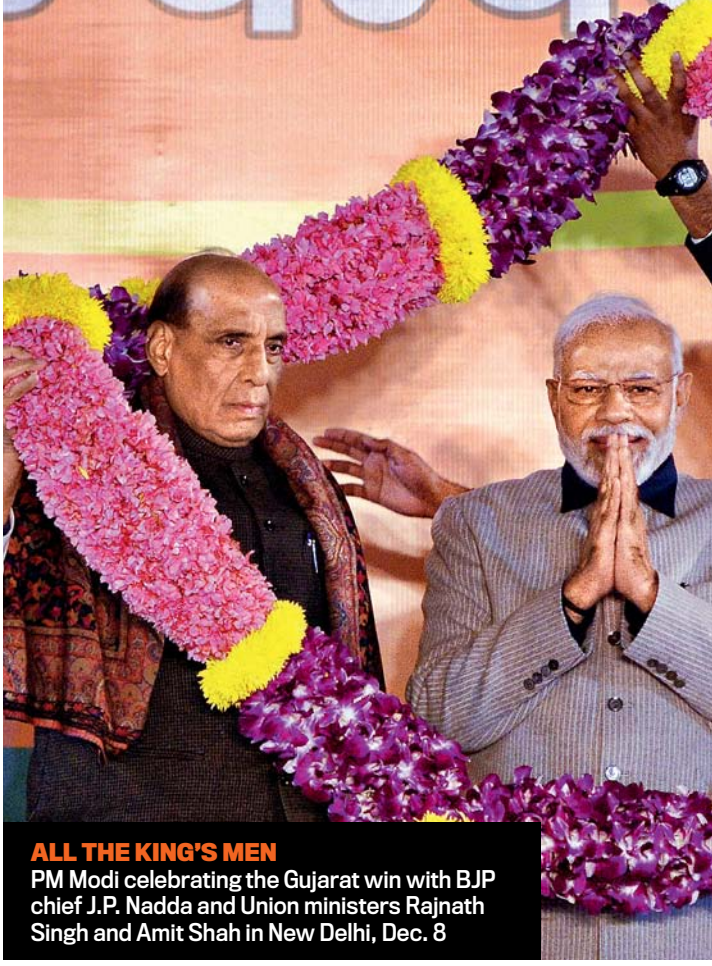
In Gujarat, for instance, the party went all out to woo the tribal communities who had voted for the Congress in 2017. The decision to involve Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS) affiliates for the groundwork in every constituency paid off. The India Today-Axis My India exit poll shows that over 33 per cent of the Scheduled Tribes voters went with the BJP compared to 27 per cent for the Congress and a surprising 31 per cent for the AAP. The tribal outreach in Gujarat is expected to have a positive fallout in Rajasthan, Chhattisgarh as well as Madhya Pradesh, three crucial states that will be going to the polls in November 2023. The Gujarat outcome will give an impetus to the party's effort to develop and expand the cadre among tribal communities.

Like in Gujarat, the BJP also changed the leadership in Karnataka and Tripura, the former slated for an assembly poll in May 2023 and the latter in February 2023. So, Basavaraj Bommai replaced B.S. Yediyurappa as chief minister in Karnataka last July and in Tripura Manik Saha took over from Biplab Deb this year in May. The moves were made in the hope of speeding up the execution of development projects, curb factionalism and dispel allegations of corruption. BJP insiders, however, say leadership change hasn't improved the situation drastically. "Again, Modi power will have to come into play to turn the tide for the BJP," says a top leader from the party.

THE MODI FACTOR

Indeed, Modi's charisma will be a significant factor in determining the outcome in three heartland states going to the polls next year—Madhya Pradesh, Chhattisgarh and Rajasthan. The BJP is beset with leadership issues in all three. In MP, some party leaders are pushing for Narendra Tomar to replace Shivraj Singh Chouhan. But the party high command is hesitant as they do not see Tomar as a pan-state leader. Similarly, the BJP remains undecided about projecting former chief ministers Vasundhara Raje and Raman Singh as CM candidates in Rajasthan and Chhattisgarh, respectively—a section of party leaders are in favour of going to the polls in these states without naming chief ministerial candidates.

Simultaneously, the BJP has centralised decision-making at various levels in the past few months. The appointments committee of the cabinet, which during the UPA's time had several ministers exchanging notes before making executive appointments, now have only PM Modi and home minister Amit Shah as members. Similarly, BJP's top two decision-making bodies—the central election committee and parliamentary board—were revamped in August. Party veterans like Shahnawaz Hussain, Shivraj Singh Chouhan and Nitin Gadkari were dropped to make way for lightweights like Iqbal Lalpura, Sudha Yadav and Satyanarayan Jatia, among others. Thus the board has been cleansed of naysayers, allowing for the will of the Modi-Shah-J.P. Nadda troika to prevail, says a BJP insider. In their private conversations, many BJP leaders voice the need to develop and nourish local satraps. "You may have Yogi in Uttar Pradesh, Himanta Biswa Sarma in Assam and Devendra Fadnavis in Maharashtra, but no new-age local satraps in other parts. The focus in the next 3-4 years should be to develop them," says a senior leader. Political observers fear that BJP is headed the Congress way when Indira Gandhi became such a cult figure in the '70s that elections were fought and won on her name. Modi is seen as being cast in the same mould, becoming at once the BJP's strength and its weakness.



CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

ALL THE KING'S MEN
PM Modi celebrating the Gujarat win with BJP chief J.P. Nadda and Union ministers Rajnath Singh and Amit Shah in New Delhi, Dec. 8